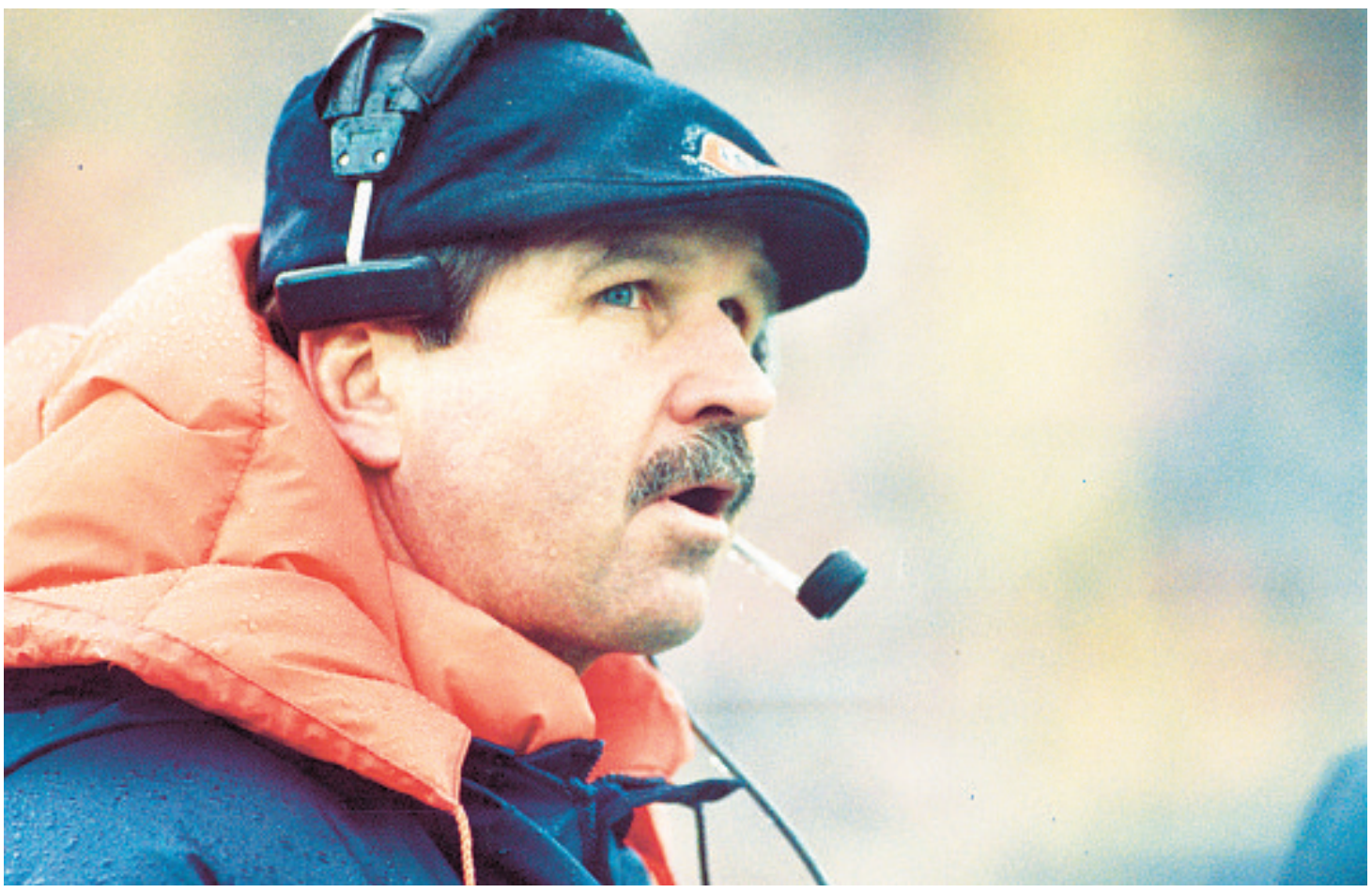
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MIKE DITKA 1939-2026



SPORTING ICON OF CHICAGO

Ditka's larger-than-life persona defined the Bears — and is forever etched in stone



Brad Biggs

Mike Ditka imagined there was a life plan for him, a vision or a calling that he was meant to do one thing.

"I believe that everyone has a destiny in life, and mine is with the Chicago Bears," he said when he was hired as the 10th head coach in franchise history Jan. 20, 1982. "I'm going to give Chicago a winning football team, an interesting football team and a football team that everybody is going to be proud of."

Ditka proved to be prophetic. He quickly restored glory to the organization. The Super Bowl XX champions — 40 years later — remain the measuring stick for everything the club does. A record-setting and Hall of Fame tight end drafted with the No. 5 pick in 1961, Ditka died Friday in Chicago, the city that adopted a guy from Western Pennsylvania as its own because of his unyielding toughness, intense determination and ability to connect with the Grabowskis. He was 86.

The Bears won the NFC Central six times during Ditka's run as head coach between 1982 and 1992, compiling a 106-62 record in the regular season and 6-6 in the postseason, including the magnificent march to a title in January 1986.

The Bears retired his No. 89 in December 2013, the 14th and final number the team retired, according to Chairman George McCaskey. A star for the 1963 NFL championship team, Ditka was a pitch man for every product and service you can imagine.

Michael Jordan may be the greatest cultural sports icon across the globe, but Ditka — decades removed from his coaching career and more than a half-century since he was a player — remained the sporting icon of Chicago, the largest personality from a team that was full of swashbuckling, sometimes-rogue characters. In a very big way, that's perhaps one reason it all worked — because Ditka showed how to walk the walk.

"There's been a lot of big-time names and big-time celebrities, but nobody has surpassed Mike's status," Hall of Fame defensive lineman Dan Hampton said. "Jordan

See **DITKA** on Page A12

INSIDE: Bob Odenkirk, the actor and Naperville native, on how Mike Ditka made "Superfans" of us all. **Chicagoland, Page A13**
Bears fans reminisced on Ditka's legacy while tailgating outside recent home games. **Chicagoland, Page A14**
Chicago mourns the Pennsylvania kid who became the ultimate symbol of our city. **Paul Sullivan in Sports**

Above: Bears coach Mike Ditka on Dec. 7, 1986. **BOB LANGER/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ELECTION 2026
U.S. SENATE

From fiery primary to low-key campaign

Stratton's supporters say she has diplomatic skills built as a mediator

By Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton may be best known among voters for the F-bomb-filled ads she ran to show she had the fight to take on President Donald Trump on her way to winning the Democratic nomination for U.S. Senate.

"F--- Trump," U.S. Sen. Tammy Duckworth and others say in the February ads, as Stratton contends: "They said it, not me."



Stratton

It was a striking message from the favorite to become the next U.S. senator from Illinois, and one that presciently summed up the Democratic base's desire for a bit more dynamism in its leaders' opposition to the Trump administration.

But underrated in Stratton's story, supporters and friends say, are the more diplomatic skills she built over more than 20 years as a mediator, qualities they see in her approach to government and politics.

And the candidate who rose to the top of the March primary with fiery ads and policy proposals that caught the eye of even the state's staunchest progressives — a

See **STRATTON** on Page A4

INSIDE

White Sox's season ends with 2-0 loss

The White Sox couldn't find sustained success at the plate all night as their improbable season ended with a 2-0 loss to the Guardians. **Coverage at chicagotribune.com**

Officials tie at least 4 deaths to Isaias

Isaias peeled off hotel and condominium rooftops and facades along Florida's panhandle before charging north Saturday. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Closing cold case, CPD says cop killed child

8-year-old girl brutally murdered in 1960

By Sam Charles
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Eight-year-old Gloria Kowalewicz's school and church were less than a half-mile from her back door in West Englewood.

On Nov. 12, 1960, a Saturday, her mother Esther was up early to get her dressed. Gloria had received her First Holy Communion recently, and a nun at St. Mary of Mount Carmel Church had urged the third grader and her classmates to receive the sacrament every day for two weeks to impress the ritual into their memories.

That Saturday was the last day. But her father needed the family car, so Gloria would have to make the 3 ½-block trip on foot.

For her daughter, the older of two kids, Esther picked out a pink-and-brown checkered dress and a blue leotard. Esther kissed her goodbye and watched from the family's porch as Gloria walked north on Damen Avenue before turning east onto Marquette Road, past a gas station and out of sight.

Gloria never made it to the church. Her body would be found just a few hours later in a secluded

See **CASE** on Page A5



Right: Girls from Gloria Kowalewicz's First Communion class walk beside her casket as it is wheeled out of St. Mary of Mount Carmel Church in Chicago on Nov. 16, 1960, following her funeral Mass. Gloria's parents, Edward and Esther Kowalewicz, follow close behind. Editor's note: This historic print shows some hand painting in the background. **CHICAGO TRIBUNE HISTORICAL PHOTO**

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TODAY	MON.	TUE.
H:77 L: 62	H:84 L: 68	H:77 L: 60

FULL WEATHER REPORT PAGE B12

INDEX

Almanac A15
Crossword ... In Comics
Editorials B1
Horoscope ... In Comics
Letters B3
Obituaries A16
Rides G7
Success G4
Television D7

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